

Chapter 45-1

After Liang Shi dropped out of high school, she worked part-time at a dessert shop.

She probably had a natural talent for cooking. At that time, she not only quickly mastered cake-making techniques but even improved the recipes. For a while, that cake shop was bustling with customers.

When she later left the dessert shop, the owner was quite reluctant to let her go.

After she started acting, she rarely had time to cook for herself, let alone make desserts.

Occasionally when she had free time, baking herself an egg tart¹ was already considered a treat.

The last time she made a mango cake for Ling Dang, it was a small one, and the method was different from this one.

This time, Liang Shi was bringing out her best skills from the bottom of her repertoire.

However, having not done this for so long, Liang Shi was also worried about messing up.

But Xu Qingzhu looked at her with such trust that she could only force herself to maintain composure, pretending to be effortlessly skilled.

Fortunately, she remembered most things.

Cooking was a relaxing process for her—she didn't need to think about anything else, just focus on what was in front of her.

Xu Qingzhu couldn't help much, so she stood at the kitchen doorway waiting.

The kitchen was large and semi-open.

Liang Shi moved back and forth at the prep counter, then suddenly exclaimed.

Xu Qingzhu quickly asked, "What's wrong?"

She hurried over to look and found that Liang Shi's shirt was stained with flour.

"I'll help you find an apron," Xu Qingzhu said while reaching up to help brush the flour off her clothes. But what had gotten on the shirt wasn't just dry flour—there was also a bit of wet mixture, and the combination wasn't easy to clean off.

"Don't bother with it," Liang Shi said. "I'll just put it in the washing machine later."

Xu Qingzhu frowned, seemingly determined to deal with that small patch of flour. "Wait a moment."

She turned and went to the living room to get a pack of wet wipes, her slender fingers pinching the wet tissue as she lifted the hem of Liang Shi's shirt with one hand.

Wind quietly slipped in along the shirt's hem, brazenly brushing against her skin.

Xu Qingzhu lowered her head, her hair falling to both sides, revealing her slender, pale neck. The curve of her spine disappeared beneath her solid-colored clothing. When Liang Shi looked down slightly, she inadvertently caught a glimpse of the spring scenery² peeking over the wall.

White, with lace trim.

The bra strap's adjustment buckle was pulled almost to her shoulder, clearly showing how thin she was.

She could even faintly see the shape of her collarbone from the side.

Liang Shi only glanced once before looking away, but when Xu Qingzhu lifted her shirt hem, her pinky finger would unconsciously curl up.

Xu Qingzhu wasn't someone who liked to keep long nails—all her nails were trimmed neat and clean. But she liked nail art, changing to new designs from time to time, though never too bold, mainly sticking to cool, light color schemes.

So at this moment, her fingertip lightly touched the skin of Liang Shi's abdomen.

The sensation of skin touching skin was very distinct. Liang Shi held her breath and sucked in her stomach.

But Xu Qingzhu's fingers were too slender. Even though Liang Shi had pulled in her abdomen to the extreme, there would still be those fleeting, barely-there touches.

Fleeting and elusive touches were the most alluring.

Liang Shi inexplicably felt that this kitchen was a bit small, even the air circulation seemed poor, making it impossible for her to breathe steadily.

Xu Qingzhu kept her eyes lowered, her expression serious. After wiping away that small patch of flour with the wet tissue, she released Liang Shi's shirt hem, but that area was now wet.

Xu Qingzhu looked a bit dejected. "Why don't you go upstairs and change clothes?"

"No need," Liang Shi immediately moved away from her. "It's fine, I'll just put on an apron."

Xu Qingzhu frowned. "Are you sure you don't need to? That water stain is quite large."

Liang Shi: "..."

There's really no need.

Xu Qingzhu didn't say anything more and took an apron down from the wall to hand to Liang Shi.

Footnotes: ¹ Egg tart: A popular Chinese pastry consisting of a flaky pastry shell filled with sweet egg custard ² Spring scenery: A Chinese euphemism referring to intimate or revealing glimpses of someone's body, derived from classical poetry